

Student Tips



Anshun Bridge in Chengdu, China

TIPS FOR READING FLUENTLY

Reading slowly, one word at a time, makes it difficult to get an overall sense of the meaning of a text. As a result, reading becomes more challenging and less interesting. In general, it is a good idea to first skim a text for the gist, and then read it again more closely so that you can focus on the most relevant details. Use these strategies to improve your reading speed:

- Read groups of words rather than individual words.
- Keep your eyes moving forward. Read through to the end of each sentence or paragraph instead of going back to reread words or phrases.
- Skip functional words (articles, prepositions, etc.) and focus on words and phrases carrying meaning—the content words.
- Use clues in the text—such as **bold** words and words in *italics*—to help you know which parts might be important and worth focusing on.
- Use section headings, as well as the first and last lines of paragraphs, to help you understand how the text is organized.
- Use context clues, affixes and parts of speech—instead of a dictionary—to guess the meaning of unfamiliar words and phrases.

TIPS FOR READING CRITICALLY

As you read, ask yourself questions about what the writer is saying, and how and why the writer is presenting the information at hand.

Important critical thinking skills for academic reading and writing:

- **Analyzing:** Examining a text in close detail in order to identify key points, similarities, and differences.
- **Applying:** Deciding how ideas or information might be relevant in a different context, e.g., applying possible solutions to problems.
- **Evaluating:** Using evidence to decide how relevant, important, or useful something is. This often involves looking at reasons for and against something.
- **Inferring:** “Reading between the lines;” in other words, identifying what a writer is saying indirectly, or implicitly, rather than directly, or explicitly.
- **Synthesizing:** Gathering appropriate information and ideas from more than one source and making a judgment, summary, or conclusion based on the evidence.
- **Reflecting:** Relating ideas and information in a text to your own personal experience and viewpoints.

TIPS FOR NOTE-TAKING

Taking notes will help you better understand the overall meaning and organization of a text. Note-taking also helps you to record the most important information for future uses—such as when you have a writing assignment. Use these techniques to make your note-taking more effective.

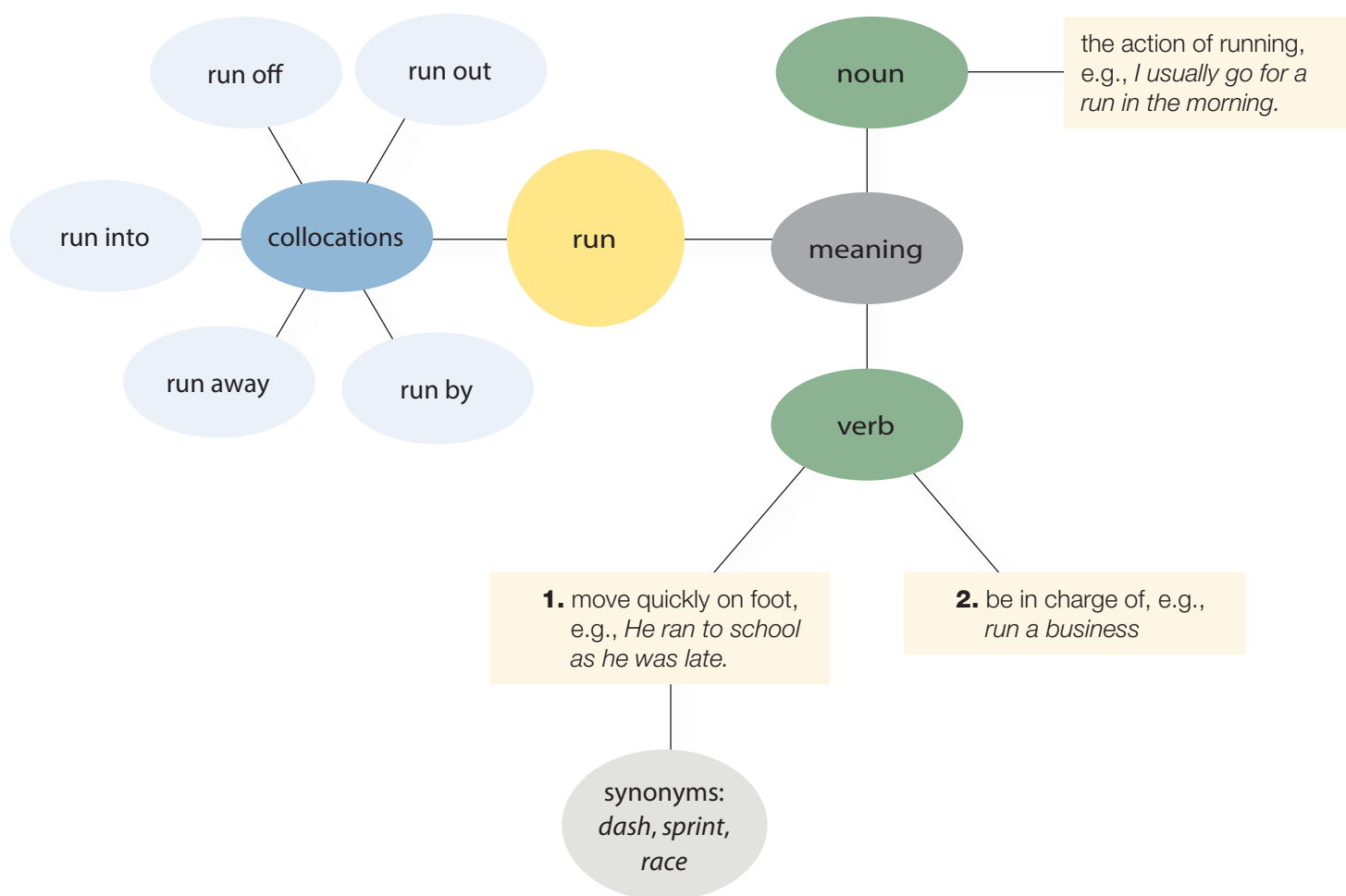
- As you read, underline or highlight important information such as dates, names, places, and other facts.
- Take notes in the margin. Note the main idea and supporting details next to each paragraph. Also note your own ideas or questions about the paragraph.
- On a separate piece of paper, write notes about the key points of the text in your own words. Include short headings, key words, page numbers, and quotations.
- Keep your notes brief by using these abbreviations and symbols. For an example of how they are used, see page 148.

<i>approx.</i>	approximately
<i>e.g./ex.</i>	example
<i>i.e.</i>	that is / in other words
<i>p. (pp.)</i>	page (pages)
<i>re:</i>	regarding, concerning
<i>yr(s)</i>	year(s)
→	leads to / causes
& or +	and
<i>b/c</i>	because
<i>w/</i>	with

TIPS FOR LEARNING VOCABULARY

You often need to use a word or phrase several times before it enters your long-term memory. Here are some strategies for successfully learning vocabulary:

- Use flash cards to test your knowledge of new vocabulary. Write the words you want to learn on one side of an index card. Write the definition and/or an example sentence that uses the word on the other side.
- Use a vocabulary journal to note down a new word or phrase. Write a short definition of the word in English and the sentence where you found it. Write another sentence of your own that uses the word. Include any common collocations (see *Word Partners* in the Vocabulary Extensions).
- Make word webs or word maps. See below for an example.
- Use memory aids to remember a word or phrase. For example, if you want to learn the idiom *keep an eye on someone*, which means to “watch someone carefully,” you might picture yourself putting your eyeball on someone’s shoulder so that you can watch the person carefully. The stranger the picture is, the more likely you will remember it!



TIPS FOR ACADEMIC WRITING

There are many types of academic writing (descriptive, argumentative/persuasive, narrative, etc.), but most types share similar characteristics. Generally, in academic writing you should:

- write in full sentences.
- use formal English. (Avoid slang or conversational expressions such as *kind of*.)
- be clear and coherent—keep to your main point; avoid technical words that the reader may not know.
- use signal words or phrases and conjunctions to connect your ideas. (See examples below.)
- have a clear point (main idea) for each paragraph.
- use a neutral point of view—avoid overuse of personal pronouns (*I, we, you*) and subjective language such as *nice* or *terrible*.
- use facts, examples, and expert opinions to support your argument.
- avoid using abbreviations or language used in texting. (Use *that is* rather than *i.e.*, and *in my opinion*, not *IMO*.)
- avoid using contractions. (Use *is not* rather than *isn't*.)
- avoid starting sentences with *or*, *and*, or *but*.

Signal Phrases

Use signal words and phrases to connect ideas and to make your writing more academic.

Giving supporting details and examples	Describing a process
One / An example of this is ... For example, ... / For instance, ...	First (of all), ... Then / Next / After that, ... As soon as ... / When ... Finally, ...
Giving reasons	Presenting contrasting ideas
This is because (of) ... One reason (for this) is ...	However, ... In contrast, ...
Describing cause and effect	Giving an opinion
Therefore, ... As a result, ... Because of this, ...	In my opinion, ... I think / feel that ... I believe (that) ...

TIPS FOR EDITING

Capitalization

Remember to capitalize:

- the first letter of the word at the beginning of every sentence.
- proper names such as names of people, geographical names, company names, and names of organizations.
- days, months, and holidays.
- the word *I*.
- the first letter of a title such as the title of a movie or a book.
- the words in titles that have meaning (content words). Don't capitalize *a*, *an*, *the*, *and*, or prepositions such as *to*, *for*, *of*, *from*, *at*, *in*, and *on*, unless they are the first word of a title (e.g., *The First Grader*).

Punctuation

- Use a period (.) at the end of any sentence that is not a question.
- Exclamation marks (!), which indicate strong feelings such as surprise or joy, are generally not used in academic writing.
- Use commas (,) to separate a list of three or more things. (*She speaks German, English, and Spanish.*)
- Use a comma after an introductory word or phrase. (*In contrast, apes can live almost 60 years.*)
- Use a comma before a combining word—*and*, *but*, *so*, *or*—that joins two sentences. (*People will visit Mars, and they will build habitation modules.*)
- Use an apostrophe (') for showing possession. (*Mars's polar regions will begin to melt, releasing more carbon dioxide trapped inside the ice.*)
- Use quotation marks (" ") to indicate the exact words used by someone else. (*"Sometimes we see ourselves as so small," says Irma, a cook at Gramacho.*)

Other Proofreading Tips

- Print out your draft and read it out loud.
- Use a colored pen to make corrections on your draft so you can see them easily when you write your next draft.
- Have someone else read your draft and give you comments or ask you questions.
- Don't depend on a computer's spell-check. When the spell-check suggests a correction, make sure you agree with it before you accept the change.
- Check the spelling and accuracy of proper nouns, numbers, and dates.
- Keep a list of spelling and grammar mistakes that you commonly make so that you can be aware of them as you edit your draft.
- Check for frequently confused words:
 - *there*, *their*, and *they're*
 - *its* and *it's*
 - *your* and *you're*
 - *to*, *too*, and *two*
 - *whose* and *who's*
 - *where*, *wear*, *we're*, and *were*